

vampires landed at the wagon, quickly dispatched of the zombies pulling it, and then flew away.

If the adventurers continue following the zombie horde's tracks for another hour, they come to a second wagon just as the zombies escorting it are being cut down. Hans and Franz, two **vampire spawn warriors** (APPENDIX B) ([PICTURE](#)), quickly dispatch the zombies with little effort.

As you continue walking, you spot the hazy form of a wagon about three hundred feet away at the mist's edge. It is slowly moving north, being pulled by three humanoids. Suddenly, two humanoids with large pale wings appear in the sky above, plunging through the mist to the wagon. There are brief sounds of a commotion; staggered groans, then silence again.

The vampires linger beside the wagon for a few minutes to chat. Hans complains about their assignment, saying this is grunt work, that his new boots are caked in mud, the bog reeks, and that there's a small hamlet not far from here they can stop by to "get a bite to eat." Franz scolds Hans, telling him to take the assignment seriously and stop complaining, that he needs to exercise more and isn't "pumped up" enough.

If the adventurers do not approach or are not spotted, the two vampires fly away after a few minutes.

If the vampires notice the adventurers and aren't immediately attacked, they try to strike up conversation:

The two figures turn to you. Both wear fine red silken clothes under their armor; red enameled plate with gold trim. Both have strange, wondrous eyes, golden iris swimming in pools of black sclera. Their pale faces wear very different expressions: one man a cold grimace, the other man a haughty smirk.

"It seems we have company, Franz," the man says, "a band of seasoned looking fellows, heading north... oh! You must be the 'Heroes of Shadowgrange!' Such an honor!" he says, performing a mock bow.

Hans wants to banter with the adventurers, as he's bored and looking for entertainment. Franz, however, is a no-nonsense kind of vampire and wants to finish taking out the corpse wagons so that they can head home.

Franz is tight-lipped when dealing with the adventurers, while Hans does entertain questions, albeit with mocking sarcasm. For example, if asked what the vampires are doing here, he replies, "taking a stroll, of course. The farbog is lovely this time of year." He does congratulate the adventurers, however, saying that the Falkenraths are happy they aided Shadowgrange and "protected the cattle." The vampires are just as opposed to the zombie horde -- and Siegfried's other machinations -- as everyone

is, because the vampires rely on healthy, thriving human settlements as food.

If asked to help defeat Siegfried, Hans explains that the alchemist is holed up in the Mauer Estate and that the building has a protective holy ward that prevents the vampires from attacking directly. He is willing to help the adventurers if they deal with Siegfried for the vampires; for example, he's willing to find out what happened to Katarina and relay that information to them, after the estate's holy wards are taken down.

The vampires defend themselves if attacked or provoked enough, but they are under strict orders not to kill the characters, a fact that Franz must remind Hans. The Falkenrath know of the adventurers' quest and would like to see the party do the dirty work of disposing Siegfried for them. If one vampire is killed, the other attempts to flee, swearing revenge (maybe returning with other vampires to attack the party in a future adventure).

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 1,050 XP equally among the characters if the party speaks with the vampires. If they manage to defeat the vampires, divide 3,600 XP instead.

CONCLUSION OF PART 4

On the end of the second day of travel, the party reaches the end of the swamp.

You leave the black muck of the farbog behind and are greeted with a fresh breeze to the open valley ahead of you. Soft rolling hills cascade ahead of you, flanked by the jagged stone valley walls.

Up a few miles ahead is a grove of greenery rising up from the short grass. Poking up from its center, high above the forest ceiling, is a twisting stone tower adorned by glistening metal contraptions. The tower shimmers with wisps of pale lights, like ribbons dancing in the breeze.

Angry dark clouds gather over the valley. They seem to concentrate over the grove, as if nature's wrath was winding up to smite the tower. Quick flashes of lightning pop from inside the restless clouds. A storm is coming...

The adventurers have nearly reached the end of their journey: Mauer Estate stands defiantly in front of them. They need only cross the valley, descend into the thicket's center, and enter.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Crossing the farbog completes a story milestone. Divide 1,200 XP equally among the characters.

There is no milestone level up for this Chapter.



CHAPTER 5: THE PERFECT STORM

Sixty miles north of Shadowgrange, nestled in a clearing at the center of a grove of live oak trees deep within northern Stensia, stands Mauer Estate. The mansion is one of the oldest buildings in the region, its foundation dating back thousands of years to a holy sect of paladins that brought the Light to Innistrad long before even Avacyn. Since then, countless occupants have claimed Mauer Estate as their home, modifying the grounds to suit their needs.

Siegfried is the estate's current owner and uses it as his base of operations. Ever since he fled Shadowgrange in the wake of his beloved Katarina's kidnapping (see "Background" in Introduction), the alchemist spends his days here working tirelessly to carry out his goal of revenge. Siegfried's descent into madness has attracted demons to his cause. The fiends aid in his work and whisper dark secrets that further taint his warped psyche.

A great storm brews overhead: part of Siegfried's machinations, in fact. The mad alchemist seeks to harness the storm's power to bring his ultimate creation to life.

The adventurers have a chance to confront Siegfried and put a stop to his nefarious schemes. And of course, untold riches await those brave enough to explore the ancient areas hidden deep inside the estate.

THE GROVE

Mauer Estate's grove is nestled deep within the farbog. The small forest is comprised of a half mile radius of oak trees ([PICTURE](#)). The trees' thick sprawling branches intertwine with their neighbors, obscuring vision and making it difficult to navigate through the area.

The oak trees are littered with what look like normal wood knots at a distance, but closer inspection shows these lumps are all have human shapes -- agonized faces, outstretched hands -- as if people were trapped inside the bark. Destroying the lumps only finds ordinary wood, however.

The telltale signs of the zombie horde's trek -- hundreds

of footprints and wagon wheels -- lead from the grove south to the swamp. Adventurers can easily track them north to the grove's main entrance, a path carved through the trees specifically to allow the horde to pass through. The branches and trees that were in the path's way were smashed and splintered by skaab abominations and the debris tossed to the side.

The adventurers don't need to follow the main path into the grove; they are free to enter the grove from any direction. However, the main path is the only method of traveling unimpeded through the grove: walking through from anywhere else requires navigating up and around the twisting jungle of low-hanging live oak branches.

LADY OF THE WOODS

The adventurers attract the curiosity of Eudora, a **dryad** (MM p121) ([PICTURE](#)) living in the grove. Eudora casts *pass without trace* before following the party sneakily.

As you make your way through the grove, you hear youthful feminine voice whisper in your ear, "My my, what do we have here? I rarely have living visitors in my woods. Who are you, and why have you come?" Out of the corner of your eyes you catch a glimpse of a feminine form flitting through the trees before its gone again with only warm laughter hanging in the air.

While Eudora probes the characters for information, the dryad uses her *tree stride* to keep a distance from the adventurers and ducks into hiding when she's out of sight, using her +15 Dexterity (Stealth).

If the adventurers explain why they are here and she is convinced that they mean her no harm, she reveals herself to them. Eudora appears as a statuesque beauty, youthful and alluring. Her hair and tight-fitting dress are made of autumn leaves: vibrant fiery hues of yellow, orange, and red. The dryad radiates vigor and primal magic.

HIPPIE PERSONALITY

Eudora is a social creature that has been deprived of humanoid companions for a long time. Because of this, she is utterly delighted to have an opportunity to speak with friendly adventurers.

The dryad places a great deal of importance on good emotions. She wants to make sure everyone is feeling "good vibes," and advocates decision making to "follow your heart" instead of cold, rational logic.

If any character is visibly upset, or if there is any fighting amongst the group, Eudora tries to intervene in mediate, asking what is wrong, and what are the deeper issues at play. Was the character abused as a child? Did they have a good relationship with their parents? The dryad loves

taking the role of a therapist and mediator.

WHAT THE DRYAD KNOWS

Eudora has never left the grove and knows little of the outside world. She doesn't know anything about current events, though she is not a fan of Avacyn due to the archangel's persecution of druidism and "the old ways" connected to the forest.

If asked about Siegfried, Eudora tells them that she helped a grief-stricken man make it to Mauer Estate (fed him goodberries and let him rest), that he would've been beautiful if his soul wasn't wracked with anger and sadness. The dryad regrets helping him, as the alchemist has been working day and night producing undead monstrosities, abominations and mockeries of nature. His foul work only causes ruin and misery.

If asked about the human-like lumps in the oak trees, Eudora explains that long ago, when Avacyn arrived, the "people of the forest" rejected her and her new religion, preferring to stick to the old ways. Avacyn punished them for this.

EUDORA'S OFFER

The dryad explains that she is lonely. Long ago, when the grove stretched all the way to the swamp, humans used to live in harmony with nature. In those times she had many visitors, many intimate friends. But slowly the forest receded and the world filled with darkness, and she was left here alone. What the dryad wants the most is a taste of that intimacy she enjoyed so long ago.

Having no love for the alchemist in Mauer Estate and his foul projects, Eudora offers to help the adventurers. She knows of a secret path that leads inside the mansion. But she wants something in return: each adventurer must stand up in front of the group and reveal an intimate secret about themselves that no one else in the group knows. Eudora explains that her most cherished moments with her intimate friends was when they left themselves emotionally open and vulnerable to others as an ultimate act of trust, and she wants to taste that experience one more time. The dryad warns that if any of them refuse her offer or lie, she will not show them the hidden passage.

This is a fun opportunity for roleplaying. It gives each character a spotlight to flesh out their characters and give the group a mutual understanding of one another. The intimate secret can be something silly, like a fear of butterflies, or more serious, like the characters' motivations for adventuring.

Eudora conducts the event like a group therapy meeting: she leads the group, asking each character in turn to share their story. She is polite and strives to keep the group a safe and calm environment, thanking each one for sharing

and taking her time to relish the experience. For example, if she particularly enjoys a story, she may close her eyes, take a deep breath, and smile as she exhales. “That felt true. I felt it, right here,” pointing to where a human’s heart would be.

DEVELOPMENTS

If each character reveals an intimate secret to the dryad’s satisfaction, or if they manage to convincingly pass off a fake tale as true, then Eudora leads them to a large live oak tree. The dryad utters a simple spell and the tree partially uproots itself, revealing a tunnel underneath: this tunnel leads to the kitchen (area A6) in Mauer Estate. The earthen tunnel is roughly dug but stable; there is no light, and the roots of the trees above dangle from its ceiling.

Eudora cannot accompany the adventurers into Mauer Estate. The dryad explains that she is magically bound to the grove and cannot leave its boundaries. The forest clearing which the estate resides is so filled with twisted magic that it’s severed from nature, making her unable to enter it. If the adventurers make a good impression on her, however, she casts *goodberry* three times and gives them the berries for their journey, wishing them good luck.

If attacked, Eudora flees, using *tree stride* to help her escape. She would much rather flee than fight.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 1,500 XP equally among the characters if the party reveals their intimate secrets.

MAUER ESTATE

If the adventurers trek to the center of the grove they eventually reach a clearing where Mauer Estate resides. The storm above them begins in earnest, pouring down heavy rain and periodically striking the rooftop with lightning. ([PICTURE](#)) ([MAP](#))

A cold rain begins pouring down as you reach the forest clearing. The heavy rainfall obscures your vision; angry gray storm clouds foaming overhead acts as a thick curtain, blocking light and leaving the clearing in a grim shadow. Leering down at you from the center of the clearing is the manor-house: Mauer Estate. Twisting up from the center of the rooftop is a stone tower, its flat ceiling crowded with a messy array of metal instrument of various shapes and sizes. Shimmering ribbons of soft pale light hang in the air surrounding the tower.

An explosive flash of lightning slams down upon a large metallic sphere atop the tower and is immediately followed by the boom of thunder. Electricity dances upon the metal apparatus and skips down long tubes attached to it that descends into the tower.

Looking around the Estate, the players hear/see:

You hear the sounds of shoveling up ahead. Circling the estate’s perimeter are humanoids shoveling the muddy earth in awkward jerky movement, sending mud flying to the side. Torn bits of muddy rags cling to their wet rotting bodies.

20 zombies (MM p316) surround the mansion, using shovels to dig a shallow trench that circles the entire building. Siegfried commanded the trench be dug for a future project to fortify his base of operations. The zombies are focused on their task, so much that adventurers could walk past them without any reaction from the undead. Attacking a zombie draws their attention, however, and 1d6+3 nearby zombies shamle over to attack the adventurers. If they lose sight of the adventurers, for example of the characters flee into the woods, then the zombies return to their work.

The main features of Mauer Estate that adventurers can reasonably spot in the heavy rain are:

- A pair of towering silvery doors on the southern side of the mansion: the main entrance (A1)
- The stables, a smaller, open building attached to the eastern wall of the estate (A7)
- Wooden double doors on the north side of the estate leading down into the cellar (A8)
- A DC 13 Wisdom (Perception) check notes two marble statues standing in alcoves flanking the main entrance. The statues are female angels in silken gowns covering their faces with their hands as they weep, the rain washing down their faces like tears. A DC 10 Intelligence (Religion) recognizes these statues as portraying angels of the flight alabaster, protectors of humans both living and dead. (These are manor gargoyles; see “Climbing the Walls” below)
- A DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check spots a stained glass window above the main entrance. It depicts an emblem with a pouncing lion. A DC 15 Intelligence (History) recognizes as the emblem of the House Lowe, an ancient family of nobles that was wiped out long ago by the neighboring vampire families.

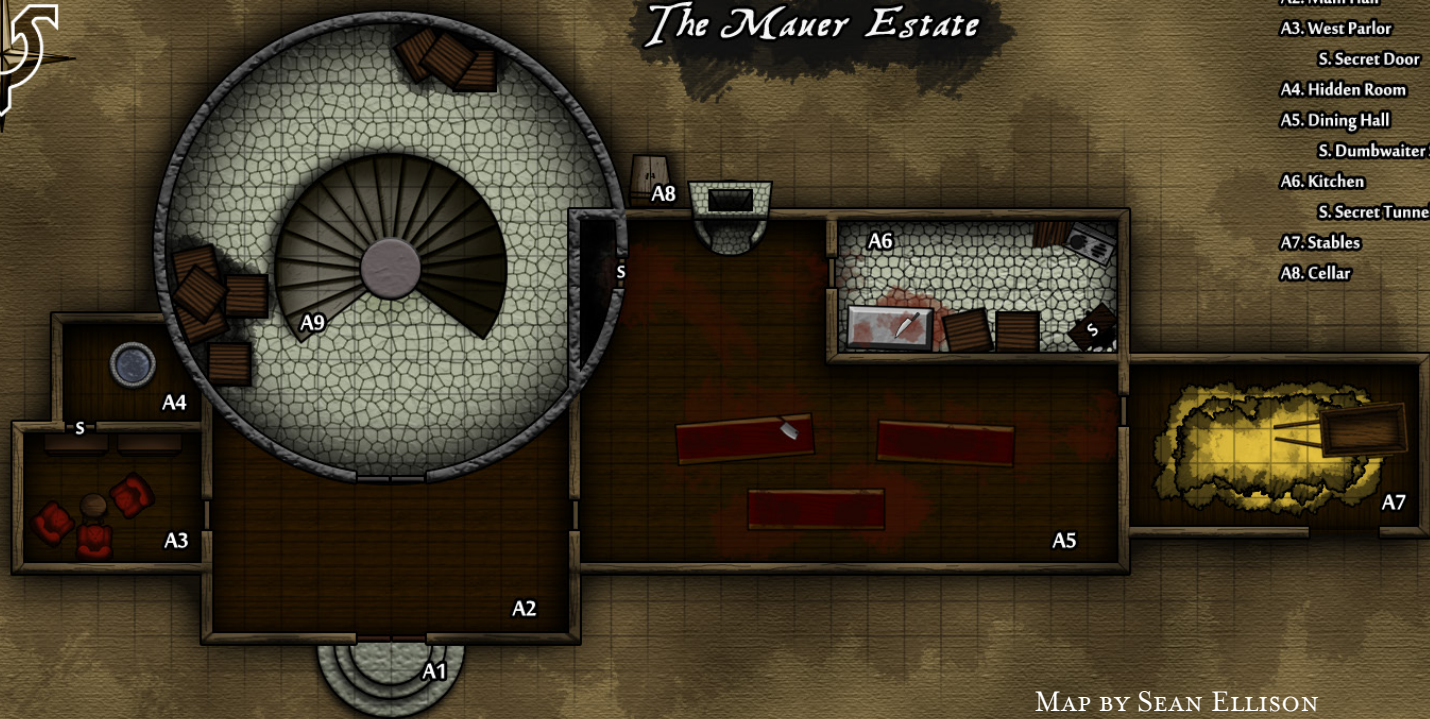
ENTERING THE ESTATE

There are four main ways of entering the estate:

- Go through the mansion’s front door (A1)
- Entering through the door connected to the stables (A7)
- Adventurers entering the estate from Eudora’s secret passage (see “Lady of the Woods”) find themselves in



The Manor Estate



- A1. Great Doors
- A2. Main Hall
- A3. West Parlor
- S. Secret Door
- A4. Hidden Room
- A5. Dining Hall
- S. Dumbwaiter Shaft
- A6. Kitchen
- S. Secret Tunnel
- A7. Stables
- A8. Cellar

MAP BY SEAN ELLISON

the kitchen (A6).

- Climb up to the rooftop and enter the laboratory (A10) through an open hatch (see “Climbing the Walls”).

Of course, creative adventurers may find other methods of entrance; roll with their zany ideas when possible!

CLIMBING THE WALLS

Unorthodox adventurers may attempt to scale the walls. Climbing the rain-slicked walls in the dark is difficult even for trained climbers, requiring a DC 20 Strength (Athletics) check.

Adventurers attempting to climb also attract the attention of the **2 manor gargoyles** (MM p140) disguised as angelic statues. They wait until the last adventurers begin their ascent before striking.

A shriek pierces the hiss of the driving rain. Swooping down at you on outstretched wings are two angelic figures with marble-like surfaces. Their statuesque feminine bodies are a stark contrast to their fiendish faces; small mischievous eyes stare at you behind a squished snout and rows of razor-sharp teeth. They make pig-like squeals and snorts as they cackle and close in on you.

In addition to their claws and bite, the gargoyles may try to drop climbers off the wall. They do so by grappling the target (action), moving away from the wall with them

(move at half speed), and dropping them (free action). The gargoyles flee if taken below 20 hit points or if one of them is destroyed.

It's nearly impossible to climb into the second floor windows; the windows are all blocked with stone and plaster. In fact, most of the second floor has been filled with earth and stone; Siegfried did away with unnecessary space, denying extra methods for would-be intruders to access his lair.

There are, however, three available ways that climbing adventurers can enter the mansion. The first is by smashing through the stained glass window into the main hall (A2). The second is going down the chimney leading to the dining hall's fireplace (A5). The third is climbing to the peak of the estate, the top of the alchemy lab (A10), where they can enter through an open ceiling hatch.

Lightning Strikes. Traversing the top of the tower is highly dangerous: lightning frequently strikes the metal apparatuses. As an adventurer climbs over, roll 1d6; on a 6, lightning strikes the top of the tower. Adventurers caught in the blast must make a DC 15 Dexterity save, taking 8d6 lightning damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a success.

WARD OF RADIANCE

Ribbons of pale light, like a miniature version of the Northern Lights, surround the tower as well. These lights are projections of pure radiant energy. Climbers in close